norns for macOS

a community port of norns to the Mac: standalone app, AUv3 plugin, script catalog. not affiliated with monome. free software under the GPL-3.0.

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1. what this is

norns is a sound computer by monome: a small box running Lua scripts, a SuperCollider audio engine and the softcut sample looper, with a 128×64 screen, three keys and three encoders. this port runs the same software natively on macOS. the window shows the device: the screen behind its bezel, the keys and encoders where they sit on a norns, played with the mouse or the computer keyboard. the community scripts run unchanged.



everything that makes a norns a norns is here: matron (scripts, screen, devices), crone and softcut (audio routing, loopers, tape), SuperCollider with the sc3-plugins, and maiden (the web editor with the script catalog). in addition the app installs an AUv3 plugin that puts norns into a DAW track.

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2. installing

requirements: a Mac with Apple silicon (M1 or later), macOS 13 Ventura or newer.

1. open `norns.dmg` and drag **norns** onto **Applications**.
2. the app is not notarized by Apple (it is ad-hoc signed, without a developer identity). the first time, **right-click norns.app → Open** and confirm. if macOS still refuses, open *System Settings* → *Privacy & Security* and click **Open Anyway**.
3. when norns asks for the microphone, allow it: that is the audio input for softcut, tape and engines. (you can change it later under *Privacy & Security* → *Microphone*.)

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3. first start

norns starts its audio server, the SuperCollider engine and maiden, then opens the norns window. the first start takes a little longer: macOS checks the bundled libraries once.

your norns lives in the folder `~/norns` in your home folder, laid out like `/home/we` on the device:

path	contents
`~/norns/dust/code`	installed scripts
`~/norns/dust/audio`	samples, tape recordings (`audio/tape`)
`~/norns/dust/data`	script data, PSETs, system settings
`~/norns/norns`	a link into the app (the norns core); do not edit
`~/norns/*.log`	logs, see files and logs

to stop norns, close its window, quit it from the Dock, or choose SLEEP in the norns menu. only one norns runs at a time.

4. controls

keyboard

while the norns window is in front, the keyboard is the norns hardware:

keys	norns
1 2 3	K1 K2 K3 (held while you hold the key, so K1 + turn works)
Q / W	E1 left / right
A / S	E2 left / right (in scripts also ↑ / ↓)
Z / X	E3 left / right (in scripts also ← / →)
with ⇧	5 steps at once; holding a key keeps turning
F1 – F4, F5	menu pages MIX, TAPE, HOME, PARAMS; F5 toggles the menu
F6 F7 F8	open or close the virtual grid, keyboard and arc

this works wherever nothing else wants the keys. when a text entry is open (naming a file, searching), you type. scripts that use the keyboard themselves (live coding, keyboard instruments, about 14 of the 350 catalog scripts) get the keys; there, hold ⌥ (Option) with the keys above, or press ⌥ Esc to force hardware keys on or off (the window title then reads *norns · keys*).

mouse

the keys and knobs in the window are the controls:

- **keys:** click K1, K2 or K3. the key stays down while you hold the mouse button.
- **knobs:** drag a knob up or right to turn it clockwise, down or left for counter-

clockwise. or scroll over it. scrolling anywhere else turns the nearest knob. hold ⇧ while dragging for fine steps, ⌘ for fast ones.

- for K1 + turn, hold 1 on the keyboard and turn a knob with the mouse.

the keys and knobs in the window always show what norns receives, also from the keyboard.

the buttons above the device

the real norns does not have these; they save trips through the menu:

button	does
MIX TAPE HOME PARAMS	opens that menu page (its light shows the page you are on). click the lit one to go back to the script.
MIC	switches the audio input (the Mac's microphone or your interface's inputs) on and off. its light is on while the input reaches norns. switch it off when speakers are loud and close to the microphone, so they cannot feed back. norns keeps the setting for the next start.
GRID ARC KEYS	open or close the virtual grid, arc and keyboard (also F6, F8, F7), see devices. the light is on while one is open. norns and the open devices are laid out together so all fit the screen; when the last one closes, norns goes back to where it was.
MAIDEN	opens maiden in your browser.
MANUAL	opens this manual.

the menu bar

menu	does
File → Import Audio or Script… ⌘O	adds audio and scripts to norns, like dropping them on the window (see files); tick *Copy audio into norns* for a copy instead of a link.
File → Show dust Folder ⇧⌘D	opens norns' dust folder (scripts, audio, data) in the Finder.
File → Show Tape Recordings ⇧⌘T	opens the folder TAPE records into.
File → Save Screenshot ⇧⌘S	saves the screen as a sharp 512×256 picture on your desktop, for sharing a script on lines or norns.community.
File → Record GIF ⇧⌘G	records the screen as an animated GIF (up to a minute, a red dot shows it is recording); the same item stops it and saves it on your desktop.
Devices	opens or closes the grid, keyboard and arc.
Devices → Audio Input from App	plays another app's sound into norns, see another app as input.

window

the window can be resized and keeps the shape of the device; the screen is always drawn with sharp pixels.

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5. audio

norns starts with the Mac's **default input and output** (*System Settings* → *Sound*) at 48 kHz with a 256-frame buffer (about 5 ms). to use an audio interface, another sample rate or a smaller buffer, go to **SYSTEM → AUDIO**:

- **E2** picks a line, **E3** changes it: INPUT, OUTPUT (an interface or *default*), RATE (44.1 to 96 kHz), BUFFER (64 to 1024 frames, with the latency next to it).
- go to APPLY and press **K3**: norns restarts its audio with the new setting, which is kept for the next start.
- if the setting does not work (say the interface cannot do that rate), norns goes back to the defaults and the AUDIO page says so. an interface that is unplugged is

replaced by the Mac's default device.

a mono microphone (like the built-in one) feeds both norns inputs. levels, monitoring, reverb and compressor are in the norns MIX menu, as on the device.

another app as input

to loop, sample or process what another app plays (a synth, a drum machine, a browser, Music) without a DAW or a loopback driver, choose **Devices → Audio Input from App** and the app. apps that are playing right now are at the top.

- the app's sound goes into norns' inputs, next to the microphone or interface (switch those off with MIC to hear only the app). scripts record and process it like anything plugged into a norns.
- the app itself goes quiet while norns takes its sound: you hear it through norns, with the input monitor level in MIX. choose *None* and the app is heard directly again; quitting norns does the same.
- the app does not have to play, or even run, yet: norns picks it up when it starts.
- the first time, macOS asks whether norns may record audio from other apps; allow it. if the app stays silent in norns, check *System Settings → Privacy & Security → Screen & System Audio Recording*.

macOS 14.2 or later. one app at a time; the choice lasts until norns quits.

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6. maiden and the script catalog

maiden is norns' web editor. with norns running, open `http://127.0.0.1:5000/maiden` in your browser.

- **project manager** (the box icon): browse the community catalog, install and update scripts. installed scripts appear in the norns SELECT menu.
- **editor**: edit everything in `dust`.
- **REPL**: the matron (Lua) and SuperCollider consoles; errors from scripts show up here.

unlike on the device, maiden and the consoles only answer on this Mac (127.0.0.1), not on your network: the consoles can run any code.

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7. scripts

scripts run unchanged. the port takes care of what differs from the device:

- scripts see the usual `/home/we/dust/…` paths; norns maps them to `~/norns`.
- the sc3-plugins (Decimator, MoogLadder, Greyhole, …) are built in.

- `require "cjson"` uses the built-in JSON library.
- shell commands find the same GNU tools as on the device.

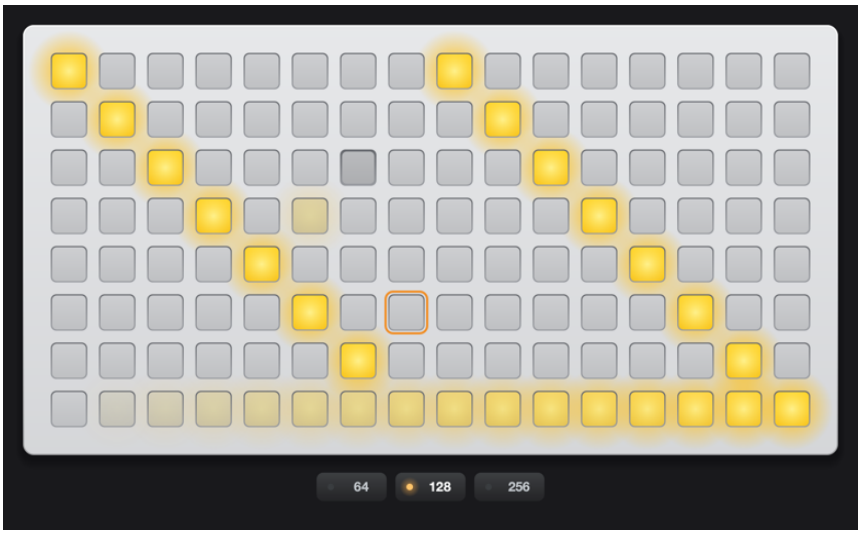
scripts that bring compiled Linux programs or Linux-only UGens, or that install software with `apt`, can fail in those parts; everything else in them still works. an engine that fails to load blocks later engine loads until you restart norns (as on the device).

new engines are compiled when norns starts: after installing a script with its own engine, restart norns (or use SYSTEM → RESTART in the menu).

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8. MIDI, grid, arc, crow, gamepads

- **MIDI**: class-compliant USB MIDI devices and network/IAC ports appear in SYSTEM → DEVICES → MIDI. norns also creates a virtual port **norns** that other apps (a DAW) can send to and receive from.
- **grid and arc**: plug them in; no serialosc needed.
- **no grid?** the GRID button (or `F6`) opens a virtual grid in its own window, as a 64 (8×8), 128 (16×8) or 256 (16×16): pick the size with the switch under it (norns keeps the choice; a script that is running may need to be loaded again to use a new size). norns and the scripts see it as a real grid (in SYSTEM → DEVICES it is *virtual grid*). click a key to press it, drag across keys to play them in turn, right-click (or ctrl-click) to hold a key down, for chords; right-click again to let it go. closing the window unplugs it.

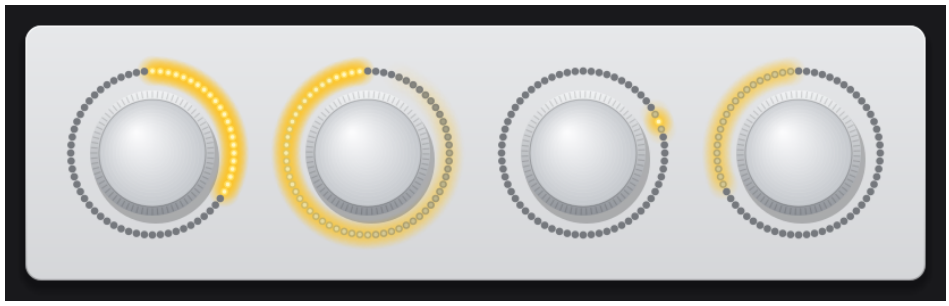


- **no MIDI keyboard?** the KEYS button (or `F7`) opens a two octave keyboard. norns and the scripts see it as the MIDI device *norns keys* (other apps, a DAW, see it too); it takes the first free port in SYSTEM → DEVICES → MIDI, so a synth script that listens to port 1 plays it right away when nothing else is plugged in. click a key to play it: near the front is loud, further back is soft. drag across keys to play them in turn. right-click (or switch on LATCH) to hold notes, for drones and chords. with the keyboard window in front, the computer keyboard plays it like a piano: `A` is C, the

row `A`–`'` the white keys, `W` `E` `T` `Y` `U` `O` `P` the black ones (by position, on any keyboard layout; the keys show their letters). `Z` / `X` move the octave, `C` / `V` the velocity.



- **no arc?** the ARC button (or `F8`) opens a virtual arc with four rings; scripts see it as an arc (in SYSTEM → DEVICES it is *monome arc virtual*). drag round a knob to turn it (clockwise is up), or scroll over it; hold `⇧` for fine turns, `⌘` for fast ones. right-click a knob to push it.



- **crow**: plug it in; it appears like on the device.
- **gamepads / joysticks**: USB and Bluetooth controllers work with scripts that support them.
- **keyboard**: the Mac keyboard is the norns keyboard (see controls).

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9. the AUv3 plugin

the app installs an Audio Unit called **norns** (a music effect: audio in, audio out, MIDI in). it puts norns into a DAW track: the track's audio goes into norns, and norns' output comes back into the track.

1. start **norns.app** (the plugin talks to it; norns keeps running in its own window).
2. in your DAW, insert **norns** on a track — in Logic as an Audio FX or MIDI-controlled effect, in Ableton Live / Bitwig / Reaper from the Audio Unit plugins.
3. press play. the plugin window shows *connected*. while the DAW plays through the plugin, norns hears the track instead of your audio interface and plays into the track instead of your speakers. when the DAW stops, norns goes back to the interface.
4. MIDI sent to the plugin track reaches norns as the MIDI device **norns AUv3** (choose

it in a script's MIDI settings or in SYSTEM → DEVICES).

latency: about 8 ms, reported to the DAW so it compensates. norns follows the DAW's clock and sample rate (it resamples internally). use one norns plugin at a time. if norns is not running, the plugin passes audio through unchanged.

if the plugin does not show up: start norns.app once from Applications, then rescan plugins in the DAW (Logic: Plug-in Manager → Reset & Rescan).

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10. files and logs

getting samples and scripts in: drop files or folders on any norns window (or choose File → Import). a note on the device says what happened.

- **audio** (wav, aiff, flac, ogg, mp3, and folders with audio in them) is *linked*: the files stay where they are, and `dust/audio/mac` gets a link to them, where sampler scripts find them like any other folder. nothing is copied, so there is nothing to clean up: deleting a link in `dust/audio/mac` never deletes your samples, and links whose files were moved or deleted are removed the next time you add something. if you move the originals or unplug their disk, norns cannot play them until they are back.
- hold ⌥ (Option) while dropping to *copy* the audio into `dust/audio` instead: for samples a saved preset should always find.
- **scripts** (a folder with a `.lua` file in it, or a single `.lua` file) are always copied to `dust/code`, because they belong to norns: maiden updates them, and norns starts the last one again on the next launch.
- **from other apps** (Voice Memos, Music, DAWs, sample browsers): many hand over a file only when it is dropped, or the sound itself. that is copied into `dust/audio`, as there is no original to link to; so is a file from a temporary folder, which the app would delete. if an app drags nothing norns can use, the note on the device says so: export the sound as a file first, or play it in with Audio Input from App.
- nothing is overwritten: a name that is already there gets a number.

getting things out: TAPE recordings are in `dust/audio/tape` (File → Show Tape Recordings); screenshots and GIFs of the screen go to your desktop.

file	what
`~/norns/norns.log`	matron and crone (Lua errors, devices)
`~/norns/sclang.log`	SuperCollider (engines, UGens)
`~/norns/jackd.log`	audio server
`~/norns/maiden.log`	maiden
`~/norns/auv3_bridge.log`	the AUv3 connection

to reset norns' settings, choose SYSTEM → RESET (or quit norns and delete `~/norns/dust/data/system.*`). your scripts and audio are untouched.

11. troubleshooting

problem	what to do
"norns cannot be opened"	right-click → Open, or *Privacy & Security* → *Open Anyway* (see installing).
SUPERCOLLIDER FAIL on the first start	macOS was still checking the bundled libraries; quit and start norns again.
no sound	check the default output in System Settings → Sound, the levels in the MIX menu, and `jackd.log`.
no input	allow the microphone for norns (Privacy & Security → Microphone); check the input level in MIX.
"norns is already running"	only one norns at a time; close the other window first.
a script misbehaves	open maiden's REPL or `norns.log` for the error.
maiden does not load	use `http://127.0.0.1:5000/maiden` (not `localhost`), with norns running.

12. differences from the device

- SYSTEM shows DEVICES, AUDIO, MODS, RESET and RESTART. Wi-Fi and the password are the Mac's job, scripts are updated in maiden, and norns itself with a new version of the app.
- the encoders are endless: E1 goes round the menu pages (after PARAMS comes MIX again). inside a page and in scripts, values stop where the page or script lets them stop.
- SYSTEM → RESTART restarts norns and SuperCollider; SLEEP quits norns (it does not put the Mac to sleep).
- no battery or screen settings: there is no battery, and the screen is a window.
- audio device and sample rate come from macOS (see audio).
- maiden and the consoles are local-only (127.0.0.1); OSC (port 10111) is reachable on your network, so phone controllers like TouchOSC work as on the device.

13. uninstalling

delete `/Applications/norns.app`. your norns folder `~/norns` (scripts, audio, data) stays; delete it too if you no longer need it.

14. source and licenses

norns for macOS is free software. the app contains, each under its own license: norns (GPL-3.0, monome and contributors), maiden (GPL-3.0), SuperCollider (GPL-3.0), sc3-plugins (GPL-2.0 or later), JACK (GPL-2.0 / LGPL-2.1), Lua (MIT), lua-cjson (MIT), liblo (LGPL-2.1), libmonome (ISC), cairo (LGPL-2.1 / MPL-1.1), SDL (zlib), libsndfile (LGPL-2.1), libsamplerate (BSD-2), nng (MIT), Boost (BSL-1.0), yaml-cpp (MIT), GNU coreutils, findutils, sed and grep (GPL-3.0), and their dependencies. the complete source of the port, with build instructions (`readme-macos.md`, `macos/setup-deps.sh`, `macos/make-app.sh`), is published with each release; GPL-3.0 grants you the right to get, study, change and share it.

norns and monome are names of monome; this port is an independent community project and is not endorsed by or affiliated with monome.